

THE HORN BOOK

M A G A Z I N E

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By SCOTT O'DELL

SAMUEL JOHNSON has said that a man may turn over half a library to make a book. It is equally true that a writer may turn over a whole lifetime to make a book. Indeed, this is what I did when I wrote *Island of the Blue Dolphins*.

Down the corridors of memory, at the far end of that labyrinth, I saw clearly a certain night.

I was four years old and I had awakened out of a long sleep. The room was dark. The sea made faint sounds among the eaves, like mice stirring. From far off came the sound of waves breaking upon the beach. Though I listened, I heard nothing else.

Lying there in my small bed, in the deep night, it suddenly came to me that the house was deserted, that I was alone. Quickly I slid to the floor and groped along the hall to my mother's room. I felt the bed. It was empty.

At that instant I heard from a distance the sound of music. By some strange alchemy of love and fear and memory, standing there in the empty room, music and my mother became one. I would find her where the music was. They would be together.

I tried to open the front door, but it was locked and the back door was locked too. Then I noticed that the window above the kitchen sink was open. I found a chair and climbed upon it and thus reached the window. (To this day I can feel the coldness of unwashed silverware on my bare feet.) I grasped the window sill, squirmed outside, hung for a moment, fell sprawling on the sand, and picked myself up.

Now the music was clear on the summer air. Against the sky I could see the glow of colored lights. I ran toward it, falling

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in the deep sand and getting up, running again, shirttails dragging at my ankles.

I came to a boardwalk. The walk led to a pavilion, to the source of the glowing lights, where clusters of people moved about. But the music was still farther, beyond them; and I went toward it, feeling my way through a forest of legs and a sea of dresses, to a place where couples drifted about.

There on a platform above them was the music and below the platform, the lights shining on her, was my mother. Her back was toward me but I knew well the golden hair. With my last breath I ran across the floor, unaware of the eyes that must have been turned upon me. I stretched out my arms and clutched her dress and though she was whirling, held on. As she turned and stared down at this apparition in a nightshirt, at her son, I am forced to say that she was not so glad to see me as I was to see her.

You will not find this incident in *Island of the Blue Dolphins*, but you will find its meaning. The human heart, lonely and in need of love, is a vessel which needs replenishing.

I saw a boy of eight, towheaded and restless, who with other boys of his age went out on Saturday mornings in sun or rain in search of the world.

This was a small world, but a world in microcosm. It was bounded by the deep water and wharves and mud flats of San Pedro Harbor. By the cliffs and reefs of Point Firmin and Portuguese Bend. By the hills of Palos Verdes, aflame with wild mustard in spring, lion-colored in summer.

Many summer days we left the landlocked world and went to sea. How? Each of us on a separate log. The logs had been towed into the harbor in great rafts—from Oregon. They were twelve feet long or longer, rough with splinters and covered with tar. But to each of us young Magellans, they were proud canoes, dugouts fashioned by ax and fire. Graceful, fierce-prowed, the equal of any storm.

We freed them from the deep-water slips where they waited for the saw mill. Astride, paddling with our hands, we set to sea, to the breakwater and beyond. We returned hours later, the watery world encompassed.

These memories went into *Island of the Blue Dolphins*. You will find them in the book—where Karana leaves the Island in search of the country that lies to the East.

Many mornings we went into the Palos Verdes Hills. There we turned over every likely rock, looking for small monsters. We thrust our hands down every squirrel and coyote hole in our path. Commonly we found an owl. This was the prize of all prizes. It was twice the size of your fist, soft-feathered, with great yellow eyes that blinked in the sudden sun.

What did we do with this creature of the nocturnal air? We killed it, of course. We wrung its neck. We cut off its legs. For the exposed tendons of an owl's legs, when pulled in a certain way, made the tiny claws open and retract in a ghastly simulation of life.

To this day, indeed to this very minute, I remember these depredations with horror.

This horror, muted but nonetheless real, you will find in the latter part of *Island of the Blue Dolphins*. The latter part of the book, only, because my Indian girl began where youth begins. In the closed world of selfishness and cruelty where everything, whether of fur or feathers, whether it creeps or walks or flies, is an object of indifferent cruelty.

Down that dark corridor of time I also saw Jack Iman.

Freckled, with black eyes alert under a bang of black hair, a Hercules in miniature, Jack hated me the moment we met. For no other reason, I am certain, than that I was a city boy, lately come to his town. I also hated him. And for no other reason except that he hated me.

In all weather, during the school week and even on Sunday, Jack pursued me. In class with his black eyes. On the school grounds with taunts. Off the school grounds with his fists. He was my nemesis. My tormentor. The embodiment to me of all evil.

Years later I read in the newspaper that Jack had become a prizefighter. Sometime later I saw him fight. I went to see him beaten. But the same Jack Iman I remembered, only with vaster muscles, was the victor. I went again and again to see him fight, each time hoping for his humiliation. Finally, after a year of fights, Jack Iman was knocked out and carried groggily from the ring. To my surprise, sitting there at ringside, I somehow felt diminished.

I went back, using the privilege of a press badge, to his dressing room. I went there to introduce myself, for I was sure he wouldn't remember me, and to quietly gloat.

Though he was just returning from another world, Jack Iman recognized me at once. Unsteadily he came towards me, put his arms around my shoulders and wept.

That too is in *Island of the Blue Dolphins*. It lies in the heart of the episode of Karana and her enemy, the Aleut girl. It also colors the climax of the book. For I believe and wished to say, with whatever power I might summon to the task, that we must forgive our enemies. Further, I believe that the hopes of civilization, unique and obscure as they are, really exist in the act of identification with our enemies.

Memories come from books, too, from that vital spring, the library. This is one of them, culled from many sources, that in spirit I used.

At Warner's Ranch, near my home in Julian, the Cupeño Indians revolted in 1851. Bereft of their ancestral lands by the Americans, impoverished and abused, they attacked under the leadership of Antonio Garra and burned a few buildings. The citizens of San Diego sprang to arms, rode in pursuit of Garra and his men. The men scattered into the chapparal, but Garra was captured and brought to trial in San Diego.

He was first tried for murder, but the evidence was lacking. The charge was changed to theft. This also lacked evidence.

Hard pressed, the court decided on a charge of treason, based upon the fact that Garra had not paid his county taxes, and sentenced him to death.

Garra joked with the firing squad as they marched him out of his cell. The attending priest reprimanded him for his levity and said that his last minutes might more appropriately be spent in prayer.

To which Garra replied: "What is the reason? I am nothing. You are nothing. This, too, is nothing."

And then, as the procession set off for the grave, he expressed the desire to walk in front, but was overruled by the priest, who again found his attitude undignified.

"Why is it undignified?" Garra asked.

The priest brought the procession to a halt. "I insist that you be more solemn. Kneel and listen to me while I pray."

Garra said, "I will listen, if it pleases you. But I will not kneel."

The priest got down on his knees and began to pray, but, upset by what had transpired, botched his Latin.

"Pardon me, Father," Garra said, "but these are the words you should use for what you are trying to say." And he supplied them from his brief studies at the mission, years before.

The priest drew himself up and began an argument which lasted until they reached the grave. In a final effort to establish decorum, he suggested that the Indian ask the pardon of all those present.

With the rifles pointed at his heart, Garra smiled and said, "Yes, gentlemen, I ask your pardon for all my offenses, and I pardon you in return."

The rifles put a period to his words and he fell into the open grave.

If Antonio Garra had killed fifty Americans or ten, his name like Geronimo's would be remembered, but he belonged to a peaceful tribe which lived amicably with each other and with the other tribes of Southern California, whose lives are unknown because they went in peace. Karana belonged to such a tribe.

Places I have known, creatures I have loved are in *Island of the Blue Dolphins*. The islands — San Nicolas, Santa Cruz, San Miguel, Catalina, Anacapa, Todos Santos, San Martín, the Coronados — seen at dawn and at sunset, in all weathers over many years. Dolphin and otter playing. A mother gull pushing her grown brood from the nest, watching them plummet a hundred feet into the sea, then flying down to herd them onto their new home, a rock safe from the tide.

And finally there is Carolina, the Tarascan girl of sixteen, who lived on the shores of Lake Pátzcuaro in central Mexico. She was one of nine children, the oldest daughter of Pedro Flores who took care of the small quinta my wife and I had rented for the summer.

The Tarascans are a great people. They were never conquered by the Aztecs, the only tribe, incidentally, that did not fall under the Aztec yoke. Nor did the Spaniards, led by the incredibly cruel Guzman, subdue them. When the Conquistadores took their capital city of Tzintzuntzan, The Place of the Humming-birds, tortured their king by dragging him around the city square attached to the tail of a horse and at last tossed him into a bonfire, the Tarascans retreated into the high mountains.

Carolina was tall for a Tarascan, with small bones but broad shoulders. Her eyes were black and deep-set, slanted at the corners, and her black hair fell heavily to her waist. She stood in her bare feet squarely on the earth as if growing from it.

Carolina, when she first came to work for us, wore a long red skirt of closely woven wool. As a bride her mother had received the gift of sixty yards of this red cloth from her betrothed, a custom of the Tarascans. With it, by winding it around and around her waist, she made a skirt. At night she used it as a blanket for herself and her husband, and later for their children, against the fierce cold of the mountains. For each girl child she cut lengths of the cloth and this in turn became a skirt. The red skirt, the *falda roja* which Carolina wore, came to her in this fashion. She wore it proudly, as a shield against the world, in the way Karana wore the skirt of cormorant feathers. The two girls are much alike.

Through them I wanted to say to children and to all those who will listen that we have a chance to come into a new relationship to the things around us. Once, in Defoe's day, we were cunning manipulative children, living in a palace of nature. In her brief lifetime, Karana made the change from that world, where everything lived only to be exploited, to a new and more meaningful world. She learned first that we each must be an island secure unto ourselves. Then, that we must "transgress our limits," in reverence for all life.

SCOTT O'DELL

A BIOGRAPHICAL NOTE

By MAUD HART LOVELACE

SCOTT O'DELL's earliest recollections are of a house standing on stilts beside the Pacific Ocean. The tide came up beneath it. This was on what is now Terminal Island, near Los Angeles, where he was born. His father was a railroader, and the family moved frequently, keeping to the same general area. Never during Scott's boyhood was he far from the wash of the sea. This is one of several factors which explain the ring of authority in *Island of the Blue Dolphins*.

From his home in San Pedro, where he lived from ages six to nine, he could almost see San Nicolas, the island on which an Indian girl had once lived alone for eighteen years. San Pedro then was a roaring port, overrun by seamen from tramp steamers and even a few sailing vessels. The school took its temper from